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How Anyone Can Help
Create Social Change

Michael Brownstein
Alex Madva
Daniel Kelly

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The MIT Press
Cambridge, Massachusetts
London, England

The MIT Press
Massachusetts Institute of Technology
77 Massachusetts Avenue, Cambridge, MA 02139
mitpress.mit.edu

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The MIT Press would like to thank the anonymous peer reviewers who provided comments on drafts of this book. The generous work of academic experts is essential for establishing the authority and quality of our publications. We acknowledge with gratitude the contributions of these otherwise uncredited readers.

This book was set in ITC Stone Serif Std and ITC Stone Sans Std by New Best-set Typesetters Ltd.

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data is available.

ISBN: 978-0-262-04978-8

10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

EU Authorised Representative: Easy Access System Europe, Mustamäe tee 50, 10621 Tallinn, Estonia | Email:
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Note to the Reader

An appendix that goes into more depth on some of the central concepts of this book is available online at www.somebody-book.com. For the sake of readability, there are no numbered notes in the main text, but readers can find further discussion of our sources in the notes section.

Introduction

By the 1920s, US car companies had a problem. More and more people were driving, but more and more people were getting killed in accidents too. Compared to a decade earlier, there were three to four times more traffic fatalities. In cities, about three-quarters of these deaths were pedestrians. A conflict was brewing about who belonged in the streets—cars or people.

One response was to try to restrict how fast cars could go. Over 10 percent of Cincinnati residents (42,000 in all) signed a petition in 1923 supporting a law to force automobile makers to install “governors” in the engines of cars that would prevent them from going over 25 mph. Unsurprisingly, the car companies resisted. Evidently, so did people who liked to speed. The industry-backed no-vote campaign squashed the proposal before it could become law.

Despite their success in Cincinnati, car companies realized that if the country was going to be redesigned for cars, they had to respond to the widespread perception that cars endangered pedestrians. Local victories weren’t enough. They needed to change the conversation.

What followed was a public relations blitz to convince Americans that cars don’t kill people, people do. John Hertz, who founded Chicago’s Yellow Cab Company and Hertz Drive-Ur-Self—which went on to become the car rental company Hertz—in 1926 declared, “[We are living in a motor age](#) . . . and we must have not only motor age education, but a motor age sense of responsibility. . . . The streets are for vehicle traffic, the sidewalks for pedestrians.”

The Chicago Motor Club searched for an expression to both describe and criticize irresponsible pedestrians. The term they coined is still with us: *jaywalkers*. It was an effective insult. A *jay* was a country bumpkin, someone clueless about city life. Hertz, revealing something about his own political sensibilities, declared, “We fear the ‘jay walker’ worse than the anarchist.”

Of course, reckless drivers also bore some of the responsibility for accidents. In 1922 the American Automobile Association offered \$25 to whoever could suggest the best new epithet for an irresponsible driver. The winner, we are delighted to report, was *flivverboob*.

According to historian Peter Norton, the car companies’ strategy was to deflect responsibility from themselves to individuals. They understood that the country’s skyrocketing traffic deaths could threaten the rise of the motor age, and they wanted to get out in front of the problem before social movements and lawmakers solved it for them.

This basic script has played out again and again since the 1920s. “[Guns don’t kill people](#), people do,” the National Rifle Association (NRA) famously claims. Smokers are “intelligent enough to make their own decisions,” Anne Browder of the Tobacco Institute said in 1985. If individuals are responsible for traffic deaths, handgun murders, and lung cancer, then car, gun, and tobacco companies can keep making money. You might lower your personal chances of getting into an accident by avoiding jaywalking or flivverboobing, but the motor age will plow ahead, undisturbed.

Fast-forward to the twenty-first century and ask yourself, What can I do to help solve any of the big problems cars create, from traffic deaths to climate change?

One option would be to focus on *personal choices*. You could sell your car and buy a bike instead. You could try to convince your friends and family to quit driving and take the bus. You might hope that, like the individual drops of water that fill up a bucket, these small changes will add up to big ones.

We feel this, and do things like these in our own lives. But we also worry that we’re buying into a century’s worth of propaganda. Isn’t this exactly what the car companies wanted, each of us taking on the responsibility of dealing with the problem they created? Sneaky PR aside, your personal choices can feel pretty inconsequential. Giving up your car isn’t going to move the needle on the national traffic fatality

rate. And how many people can you, personally, persuade to give up their own vehicles? The US is an awfully big bucket to fill drop by drop. And that's just the US.

So you could consider an alternative: pass better laws. Rather than fret about your personal choices, *change the system*. You could advocate for “congestion pricing” that makes it expensive for people to drive into cities. Or get your city to invest in bicycle infrastructure, public transportation, or European-style car-free zones in city centers. These are all ways of changing the systems that shape the choices individuals make.

But while focusing on your personal choices can feel insignificant—or like succumbing to corporate propaganda—trying to change the system can feel overwhelming, a gargantuan undertaking with long odds of success. You probably know how to ride a bike, but what about implementing congestion pricing or ending car culture?

A Better Picture

The philosopher and novelist Iris Murdoch once remarked, with characteristic elegance, that “man is the creature that makes pictures of himself and then comes to resemble the picture.” We’ve come to resemble the picture painted by Hertz, the NRA, and Big Tobacco, inheriting a view of ourselves and social change that is compelling, entrenched—and wrong. It seems to offer a stark choice: if you want to make change, you can focus on yourself, or you can focus on the system. You can quit driving, or you can try to end car culture. That’s a terrible choice, since the first seems ineffective and the second beyond our reach.

The three of us spent a long time feeling stuck about what we could do about the biggest problems we collectively face, problems like climate change, racism, and yes, car culture. It seemed to us that we were being forced to choose between personal choices or systems and social structures.

This book is about getting unstuck. Our personal choices *do* matter, just not the way we usually think.

Part of why it’s hard to see this is that would-be changemakers are constantly told they have to choose: change people or change systems. “You can’t save the climate by going vegan,” a *USA Today* op-ed proclaimed in June 2019. “Corporate polluters must be held accountable.” This widely circulated essay argued that focusing on individual actions like what to eat and how to travel “[distract from the systemic changes](#) that are needed to avert this crisis.”

From our perspective, the authors are right that the climate crisis is only going to be solved with systemic change. They’re also right to be suspicious of putting the responsibility for change at the feet of individual consumers.

But the authors’ overall message falls short: They make what we shouldn’t do much clearer than what we should. “Don’t change lightbulbs,” they say, “change [the] energy system.” The first part of this message seems straightforward. Stop stressing over individual actions like how to light homes and stock fridges. Got it. But what to do instead? What can any of us do to hold corporate polluters accountable and overhaul energy infrastructure? The philosopher Robin Zheng put the crucial unasked question this way: “[what is my role in changing the system?](#)”

Lurking in the background of *USA Today*’s op-ed—and behind the dominant cultural conversation about social change—is the portrayal of people as isolated from each other, with limited reach, able to adjust a few things here and there in their own personal lives but not much else. It highlights divisions rather than connections, boundaries rather than pathways of influence. It underlines opposition: real-deal change is taking down the car companies or fossil fuel industry rather than making changes in your own life.

We need a better picture, one that highlights how personal choices are connected to systems and structural change. We need a picture that foregrounds our most powerful personal choice: to work together with others. As the writer Bill McKibben put it about climate change, “[the most important thing](#) an individual can do is be somewhat less of an individual, joined together with others in movements large enough to make those changes on [a] more fundamental level.”

We need images and models and stories that help us see what kinds of personal choices merely make us feel good but are basically ineffectual, and what kinds actually have the potential to create transformative social change. This book assembles these images and models and tells many of these stories. It offers them in service of getting unstuck.

Structural Change and Individual Change

The most pressing social problems are incredibly complex. Take climate change. There's no one fundamental solution because [climate change is an “everything problem.”](#) It results from how billions of people commute and travel, grow food, make clothes and medicine, ship things around the world, get rid of trash, build homes and roads and cities, and keep themselves warm in the winter and cool in the summer. Each of these factors contributes to climate change, and they're all interconnected.

Climate change encompasses laws, institutions, political economies, cultures, and all the interconnections between them. Call these *social structures*. Seriously addressing the problem requires *structural change*.

Everyone doesn't contribute equally, of course. [An average American refrigerator](#) uses more electricity in a year than the average person does in Kenya, Nigeria, or Tanzania. The US and the European Union have produced about half of all historic greenhouse gases, but their people, especially the wealthy, are likely to be shielded from the worst of its effects. (No one will be completely shielded, though.) These facts have led many people to realize that climate change—in addition to requiring a massive overhaul of energy systems, food systems, and so much else—is also a matter of justice. Responding to it fairly will require redistributing global wealth and power.

No one thinks solving these sprawling everything problems will be easy. But pure uncut pessimism can be paralyzing, and isn't justified anyway. In the US, at the time we're writing this book, per capita carbon pollution emissions are [below where they were in 1913](#). The clean energy economy is growing furiously. As we'll see, there are all kinds of ways in which people can contribute to making progress on these everything problems.

Still, coming to grips with the structural nature of a planet-sized problem like climate change makes it incredibly difficult to know what to do about it. This can be demoralizing. The three of us grew up in the era of “reduce, reuse, recycle,” a slogan that made things seem simple. If everyone cared enough and did their part, we could solve the problem. One of us—Michael—even had a recycling-themed bar mitzvah, replete with giant balloons that looked like the Earth. (Sorry, sea turtles.)

Thirteen-year-old Michael was naïve, but having tangible things to do is an appealing alternative to “change the whole system.” How does one go about changing social structures anyway? Where to even start? The three of us know how to recycle—though even that can be a source of confusion and marital friction—but we don't know how to decarbonize the power grid, let alone redistribute global wealth and power.

It's all too easy to be daunted into inaction. Between 1985 and 2022, Greenland lost one trillion tons of ice—that's 30 million tons melted *every hour*. But the angst-inducing size of the problem is no excuse for accepting the status quo, sticking our heads in the sand while vacationing in Fiji. If we don't stop pumping carbon pollution into the air, Fiji won't be there anymore. It will be underwater, along with Bangkok, Ho Chi Minh City, Jakarta, Manila, New Orleans, Shanghai, the West Netherlands, and a whole bunch of other places.

The burdens of climate change fall disproportionately on the world's communities of color. And racism is itself another complex, structural, everything problem. Understanding how to combat it also requires unlearning myths many of us were taught as kids, which, like the corporate picture of climate change, focuses attention on individual bad guys and good guys. Whatever the problem, its causes and solutions have faces and names. The fairytale about racism is that it came from villains who hated Black people and

was fought by heroes like Frederick Douglass, Abraham Lincoln, Rosa Parks, and Martin Luther King Jr. who vanquished them. The general lesson we learned as kids is that evils like racism are caused by racists, just like pollution is caused by litterbugs.

The reality is that racial injustice is embedded in a dense thicket of interconnected social systems. Racial segregation, for example, wasn't just started and perpetuated by individually racist homeowners or race-baiting politicians. And it didn't end after civil rights activists like Parks and King marched and dreamed. [Segregation is an essential throughline](#) of American history, running from the founding fathers through slaveholders and outspoken segregationists to New Dealers and mortgage bankers, all the way up to the present and the nice white parents who just want their kids to go to the "best" schools.

Just as it's naïve to think that we can recycle our way out of climate change, it's similarly naïve to think that systemic racism will be overcome when each of us becomes a little less prejudiced. Treating everyone fairly and kindly is an excellent thing to do, but that alone won't undo the racial wealth gap or eliminate medical apartheid.

So what are you supposed to do? Bias and prejudice are relatively easy to recognize, even if they are hard to completely avoid. But how do you challenge systemic racism? Can you do it without quitting your job and [becoming a full-time revolutionary](#)?

People Who Change Systems That Change People

For the purposes of this book, we're not going to try to convince you that climate change and racism are bad, or explore the essence of what makes them so. We'll just assume they're bad and assume you agree. We're not going to make specific policy recommendations either. We're not wonks. We're three philosophers frustrated by the wrong lessons we were taught about these systemic problems. We've spent a long time thinking about what a better picture, and a better set of tools for thinking about social change, would look like.

In the chapters that follow, we'll meet union organizers, reproductive rights activists, city planners, and a whole bunch of ordinary, busy, imperfect people who have found ways to connect their personal choices to systemic change. One thing that unites these people is that they see systems and institutions as mutable, and see themselves as *part of* those systems and institutions, not separate from them. This is the central idea we'll explore, mapping out its implications across a whole swath of contexts. The people we'll profile have found ways to take advantage of human beings' unavoidable, radical interdependence. That we're so deeply interconnected is [an idea found across contemporary social science](#).

[Our focus will be on climate change and racism](#), two areas where the old picture—individual choices outmatched by systemic forces—retains a strong grip. There's another reason too: race and climate change are intimately related. As Fijians and people of color the world over have been telling anyone who'll listen, the effects of pumping billions of tons of carbon pollution into the atmosphere are devastating their communities *now*. Still, our main point of departure will be how these issues arise in the US, the context we three are best poised to study. Where we can, though, we'll venture a more global perspective.

The book has three parts. The first diagnoses the problem of "either/or" thinking about social change that stems from the seemingly forced choice between making better personal choices and changing the system. The second offers a different way to think about social change, anchored in a more accurate picture of human nature. The third explores ways of putting this picture into practice.

From learning to pay attention to systemic causes of injustice to building social movements, we need a "both/and" approach. We need to make personal choices that help change systems and to build systems that help people make better choices.

I

The Problem of Either/Or Thinking About Social Change

You Do You: The Misdirected Individualist History of Climate Activism

People Start Pollution . . . So People Can Stop It?

If you've watched any TV show or movie made between 1930 and 1990 that features a Native American character, chances are you've seen the actor known as Iron Eyes Cody. He starred in movies alongside Roy Rogers and John Wayne and in TV shows like *The Cisco Kid*, where he played Chief Sky Eagle. His career was illustrious. Cody appeared in over 200 films and 100 TV shows. He was a close friend of Walt Disney. He has a Hollywood star. He chants in the background of Joni Mitchell's 1998 song "Lakota."

As you might have guessed from his name, Iron Eyes Cody didn't just play Native American characters onscreen. He lived the role. Off camera, he was usually seen wearing the same beaded moccasins and fringed leather he wore on camera. He appeared in documentaries discussing Native American sign language. [He was reputedly](#) very generous to Native American charities. Often, he spoke about his Cherokee father and Cree mother.

Maybe this wholeheartedness contributed to the success of Iron Eyes Cody's most famous role. [He played the "Crying Indian"](#) in what is usually regarded as the most successful public service announcement (PSA) of all time. Launched on Earth Day in 1971 by a group called Keep America Beautiful, the PSA opens with Cody paddling his canoe down a pristine river in full buckskin. Ominous drums beat in the background.

But the river turns out to be not so pristine. First you see a single piece of floating trash. Then, as if you've flashed through the Industrial Revolution on a geologic timetable, Cody is surrounded by litter, heavy industry, and a crowded highway. Just after Cody pulls his canoe onto a trash-strewn shore, a driver speeds by and tosses what looks like a week's worth of garbage at his feet. Cody remains silent. A stern-sounding narrator reads the famous words, as Cody slowly turns to face the camera, a tear sliding down his cheek: "Some people have a deep abiding respect for the natural beauty that was once this country. And some people don't. People start pollution . . . and people can stop it."

The PSA was immediately celebrated. [It won multiple awards](#) and is widely cited as instrumental in reducing roadside litter. Even when tested today, the decades-old ad is rated highly, and audiences endorse its message.

Timing might have been one factor driving the ad's success. In 1971, [collective acknowledgment of the genocide](#) that Native Americans suffered at the hands of European Americans was growing. The ad evokes a sense of guilt for those horrors and then yokes one guilt to another: culpability for polluting the planet. But the ad doesn't just leave viewers to stew in shame. It also empowers them. People start pollution, but *people can stop it*.

The ad plays on the intuitive idea that little things add up. They can add up for worse (polluting) or for better (cleaning pollution up). If each of us just takes responsibility for our tiny corner of the world, then and only then will we fix the collective messes we've made.

As natural as this logic is, [the message is catastrophically misleading](#). So was the ad. It might have helped reduce roadside litter, but that wasn't its real purpose.

Disciples of Disposability: The Big Business of Blaming Individuals

In the years before his death at age ninety-four, Cody spent much of his time giving talks to Native

Americans, often admonishing them about gambling and alcohol. That he spent his twilight years telling Native Americans how to improve themselves is perhaps the bitterest of Cody's ironies. Because Cody wasn't Native American. His given name was Espera Oscar de Corti, and he was second-generation Italian American. His parents were not Cherokee and Cree; they were Sicilian. He was raised in Gueydan, Louisiana, with three siblings, two of whom, oddly, also went on to play Native Americans in film.

American history is full of frauds and con artists, from Frank Abagnale to Bernie Madoff. What makes Iron Eyes Cody's lifelong con particularly interesting, however, is that it's tied to another one, a fraud reaching far beyond Hollywood.

According to its website, [Keep America Beautiful](#)—the group that made the PSA—was formed when “a group of corporate and civic leaders met in New York City to bring the public and private sectors together to develop and promote a national cleanliness ethic.” Among those civic-minded founders so very earnestly concerned with national cleanliness were executives from beer, can, bottle, soft drink, chewing gum, candy, and cigarette companies. The group's chairman was himself president of the American Can Company.

Keep America Beautiful was formed when disposable containers were relatively new and increasingly popular. People in postwar America were trying to figure out how to solve the problems those disposable containers caused. One of those problems was that broken bottles cut cows' feet and damaged farm equipment. In response, the Vermont Supreme Court had upheld a law banning the sale of beer or ale in nonreturnable glass containers just six months before Keep America Beautiful was formed. This kind of law cut directly into the profits of the so-called “disciples of disposability”—the CEOs of beer, bottle, soft drink, candy, gum, and cigarette companies.

The CEOs decided that something had to be done. Their task was to stop more of these laws from being passed. The strategy they adopted was to steer people away from lobbying their state representatives to ban single-use containers. Instead, they aimed to convince people to take personal responsibility for the problem. [The Crying Indian ad was their masterstroke.](#)

Blaming individual people didn't stop with bottles and cans. Keep America Beautiful collaborated with the American Ad Council, which created Smokey the Bear (“Only *you* can prevent forest fires!”), McGruff the Crime Dog (“Take a bite out of crime!”), and aphorisms like “[friends don't let friends drive drunk.](#)” They invented the term “litterbug” too.

All these campaigns take a social problem and make it about personal responsibility. The Ad Council Archives at the University of Illinois contains a zinger that displays the logic behind these PSAs with remarkable clarity. It's from [a 1994 message about water pollution](#): “There are toxic chemicals in our water. Such as oil. And pesticides. You might think industry is to blame. But they're only part of the problem. You and I, in our everyday lives, are also responsible for a tremendous amount of water pollution.”

As with the Crying Indian ad, this one plays on two very powerful feelings: guilt and empowerment. First, you're made to feel guilty for doing ordinary things, like watering your lawn. Second, you're made to feel responsible in a way that's empowering: you can do something to help!

The insidiousness of this is that you're not being told to shut up and deal with it. But the way you're being invited to help also doesn't [threaten anyone's bottom line](#). So long as everyone is busy with anti-litter campaigns, the Ad Council accurately predicted, we won't bother passing restrictive laws. That's why these messages have had catastrophic effects. They take one important thing—it *is* good to clean up after ourselves—and use it to distract us from something even more important: holding big businesses and governments to account for tackling pollution head on.

Your Footprint, Your Responsibility

The more recent notion of everyone having a “personal carbon footprint” has similar roots in the dark arts of corporate PR. The oil giant [BP popularized the term](#) and bent it to its own purposes (figure 1.1).

BP worked from the same playbook as the Ad Council. After acknowledging that climate change exists, the company makes you feel responsible for it. And then they give you something to do that helps you *feel* like you're part of the solution. Meanwhile, BP continues pumping away, enjoying massive federal subsidies and outlandish profits while avoiding any new, restrictive regulations.

The strategy was popular. One analysis of decades of ExxonMobil's public communications found that the corporation framed climate change in terms of consumer energy demand when speaking publicly. But in internal company documents, ExxonMobil recognized that it could not continue to supply fossil fuels without [disastrous consequences to the environment](#). They knew they were causing the problem (supply) but put the blame on us (consumer demand).

ExxonMobil even conducted its own secret research on climate change in the 1970s. The results were consistent with scientific predictions. The corporation's in-house models predicted that global temperatures would rise to within 0.2°C of what they have in fact risen to since. While it publicly claimed in 1997 that "some of today's prophets of doom from global warming were predicting the coming of a new ice age," in the 1970s, [Exxon's own scientists](#) had privately been in agreement all along with the overwhelming majority of published science on climate forecasting.

What on earth is a carbon footprint?

Every person in the world has one. It's the amount of carbon dioxide emitted due to our daily activities—from washing a load of laundry to driving a car load of kids to school. Find out the size of your household's carbon footprint, learn how you can reduce it, and see how we're reducing ours at bp.com/carbonfootprint. It's a start.



beyond petroleum®

bp.com

Figure 1.1

BP advertisement. Screenshot of advertisement appearing in various publications from 2004 to 2006.

Once you know what to look for, you start to see the message of personal responsibility everywhere. Worried about retirement? Start saving more. Have a gambling problem? Exercise some willpower and stay away from the casino. Worried about obesity? Fix your lifestyle. From 2008 to 2010, 87 percent of all alcohol ads in magazines [told consumers to “drink responsibly.”](#)

While it was becoming clearer that Americans consume too much sugar, [Coca-Cola fought back](#) by subsidizing research arguing that the problem was not calories in but calories out: “Americans are overly fixated on how much they eat and drink while not paying enough attention to exercise.” The central plank of the food industry’s lobbying has been to frame discussions about eating habits in terms of personal responsibility (e.g., “portion control”).

What these messages minimize are all the social, structural, and systemic drivers of health problems like diabetes. In one *New York Times* article, [Dr. Dean Schillinger explained](#) how “our entire society is perfectly designed to create Type 2 diabetes.” There is no amount of scolding about sugary foods and exercise, he explains, and “no device, no drug powerful enough to counter the effects of poverty, pollution,

stress, a broken food system, cities that are hard to navigate on foot and inequitable access to health care, particularly in minority communities.”

Yet these companies have devoted enormous amounts of money to teaching the public to focus on the symptoms rather than the underlying system. They have taught us to track what we buy, and take responsibility for what we do with the stuff we buy, so that they won't have to stop making and selling the stuff we buy from them or deal with laws regulating how they do it.

A Too-Convenient Model for Facing Inconvenient Truths

Whole social movements have been built around this individualist, little-things-add-up ethos. An iconic poster from the early days of the modern environmental movement mirrors the Ad Council's claim that personal choices are both the cause of and the solution to pollution (figure 1.2).

This individualist thinking prevailed all the way from the 1970s environmental movement to May 2006, which marks one of the biggest box office events in documentary history: the release of Al Gore's *An Inconvenient Truth*. The documentary reached millions of people around the world. Its vivid depictions of solar rays pelting the atmosphere and glaciers melting raised public awareness of climate change to new heights and ignited collective fervor about the environment like never before. It demanded action.

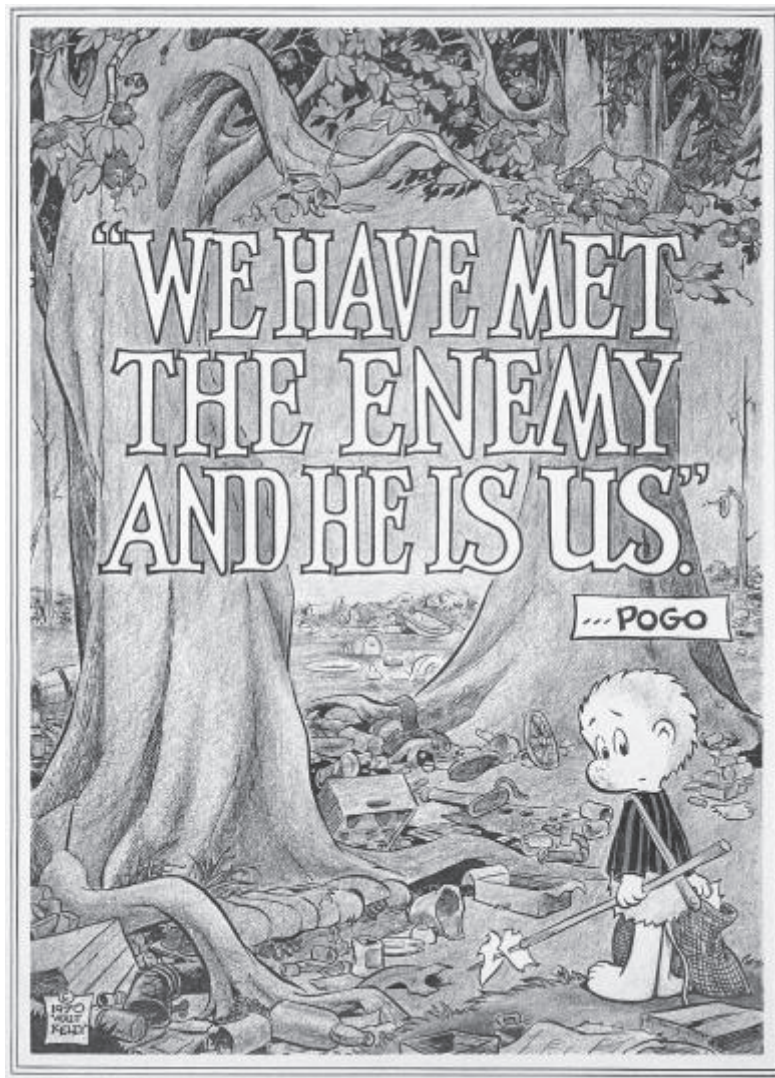


Figure 1.2

Earth Day poster created by Walt Kelly, 1970.

Widely and deservedly lauded, *An Inconvenient Truth* presented the facts in a way that was hard to argue with. It also presented solutions:

Each one of us is a cause of global warming, but each one of us can make choices to change that with the things we buy, the electricity we use, the cars we drive; we can make choices to bring our individual carbon emissions to zero. The solutions are in our hands, we just have to have the determination to make it happen. We have everything that we need to reduce carbon emissions, everything but political will. But in America, the will to act is a renewable resource.

The general template should sound familiar. What causes climate change? We do. How? Driving gas guzzlers, leaving on the lights, and buying unrecyclable plastic. What's the solution? Stop doing these things. Consume better.

This is another effect of the long history of corporate-funded individualist messaging: the first thing that comes to mind for many of us when we ask “what can I do?” is a series of thoughts about *stuff*. What should I buy? Where should I buy it from? What should I do with it? Even leaders in the fight against

climate change have perpetuated our preoccupation with consumption.

As the credits of *An Inconvenient Truth* roll, [the film offers concrete suggestions](#) for how to make a difference, stating, “The climate crisis can be solved. Here’s how to start.” Here are the first five items in the list:

- Buy energy-efficient appliances + lightbulbs.
- Change your thermostat . . . to reduce energy for heating + cooling.
- Weatherize your house, increase insulation, get an energy audit.
- Recycle.
- If you can, buy a hybrid car.

These are good things to do, though energy-inefficient incandescent lightbulbs are basically illegal now and hybrid cars may be on their way to being old news. But *An Inconvenient Truth* exemplifies a whole world of books, TV, and academic research that looks at climate change through the lens of our personal consumer choices. Even academics have gotten in on the act. One widely cited study examined and ranked nearly 150 personal lifestyle choices by their effectiveness in reducing personal carbon footprints. [The four most impactful options](#), it found, are having one fewer child, living car-free, flying less, and eating a plant-based diet.

Eventually, further down the list of action items, *An Inconvenient Truth* also tells viewers to do the following:

- Vote for leaders who pledge to solve this crisis.
- Write to congress.
If they don’t listen, run for congress.
- Speak up in your community.
- Insist that America freeze CO₂ emissions + join international efforts to stop global warming.

These suggestions head in a different direction, away from what we buy. They gesture toward our political choices and our communities’ values. This is promising, and we’ll talk a lot more about why in the coming chapters. For now, notice how vague they are. “Speak up in your community” sounds empowering, but what does it really mean? Speak up to whom? Say what? “Join international efforts” sounds good too. But your average moviegoer may be forgiven for thinking, “Yeah, I’ll get right on that.” Most viewers likely walked out feeling alarmed, maybe intending to buy better lightbulbs. After all, lightbulbs were first on the list!

It turns out audiences did become both [more knowledgeable and more concerned](#) about the climate crisis. But this newfound knowledge and concern doesn’t appear to have amounted to much, at least in the short term. One study found that a month after seeing the film, viewers had done next to nothing to put their newfound climate knowledge into action. Not one of them had examined their carbon footprint or written a letter to their senator.

Another study found that framing solutions in terms of individual consumer choices *decreases* people’s willingness to take other forms of action to fight climate change. Maybe people feel like they’re being blamed for a global crisis beyond their control. Maybe they resent being asked to respond with what to them look like merely symbolic, even futile, [changes to their personal behavior](#). The danger, then, is not just that such messages don’t help. It’s that they might be making things worse.

System Change, Not Climate Change

Some people have started to get wise to this long history of corporations laying problems at the feet of

individuals. The backlash it's helped create has produced slogans now found on fridge magnets, protest posters, and newspaper headlines. The most common ones suggest a different kind of thing to do: stop worrying about personal choices, and start focusing on changing the system. The news site *Vox* published an article in 2019 whose headline perfectly expresses this idea: "I Work in the Environmental Movement. [I Don't Care if You Recycle.](#)"

The Sunrise Movement, a decentralized, youth-led group at the forefront of progressive climate politics, advocates system change: "to abolish or reimagine institutions that degrade our communities and our climate." This marks a generational sea change in climate activism. Abolishing or reimagining institutions was most certainly not on *An Inconvenient Truth*'s list. Writing for the *New Yorker*, Andrew Marantz recounts a telling experience with a Sunrise group in Philadelphia:

The organizers were scanning the menu of a Middle Eastern restaurant on Uber Eats. Aru Shiney-Ajay, Sunrise's training director, sat at a laptop, taking orders. "Can you get me a beef kebab?" Dejah Powell, an organizer from Chicago, said. "Or, no. Beef is the worst, right? Maybe chicken. Or falafel?"

"Dejah," an activist named John Paul Mejia said, in a mock-scolding tone. He started reciting a movement adage, using the singsong rhythm of a call-and-response: "The biggest driver of emissions is . . ." The others joined him, in unison: ". . . the political power of the fossil-fuel industry, not individual behavior." In other words, [if you want the beef, get the beef.](#)

One way to think about Sunrise's system-over-individual logic is to recall Iron Eyes Cody. We called him a fraud, but looked at another way, his personal deception obscures the bigger story. A first-generation Sicilian American was able to play some of the most iconic Native American roles in Hollywood because the movie industry excluded actual Native Americans from taking those roles. The biases woven into cultural norms and movie business practices allowed, and incentivized, Cody's personal fraud. Too much focus on what he should or shouldn't have done, as a single person, makes it easy to overlook the system that structured his options and made his personal choices possible in the first place. Coming to appreciate the significance of systems can be disorienting, but keeping that significance firmly in view is crucial to understanding the bigger picture. The little-things-add-up take on individual responsibility is too easily weaponized by corporations advancing their own interests. When it comes to climate change, they have long pushed a picture where "taking action" means tweaking our shopping choices. It's this history that Sunrise and other progressive climate activists are rightly [standing athwart, yelling stop.](#)

But even if we accept this change in perspective, it's not at all obvious what we should do next. To take that step, we'll look at another area of life where a loud chorus is rightly demanding structural change.

Structural Injustice: Why Conversations About Racism Become Conversations About Real Estate

The Accumulation of (Dis)advantage

Everyone gets to make choices, but we don't all get the same options. The differences between people's options are shaped by social structures.

Imagine 100 people have fallen behind on rent. They receive an ominous notice from the city about a court date to attend or else they'll be evicted. Of these people, 50 are Black, and 50 are white. Each wants desperately to show up and contest the eviction. Let's say a few from each group oversleep. So we're down to 48 left in the running to make their court date in each group. What else might prevent these people from making it?

In many places, neighborhoods with more Black Americans suffer more power outages than predominantly white neighborhoods. So maybe while some of our 100 people made a mistake setting the alarm, one or two more Black people oversleep when their unpowered alarms don't wake them up. We're down to 47 Black people and 48 white.

Some of these people work at fast-food restaurants. Unfortunately, over half of service sector workers, and three-quarters of fast-food workers, get their schedule less than two weeks in advance. So some of our remaining 95 people won't have received their schedule in time to get the day off. They'll have to make a terrible choice: go to court or keep their job. Black people are much more likely than white people to work in service, so let's say 5 Black people opt to skip court to go to work, while only 3 white people do. We're down to 42 Black people versus 45 white.

Among our remaining 87, a bunch will need childcare. For some, a friend or family member can help out. Others are lucky enough to live near affordable daycare or free pre-K. But the breakdown won't be equal here either. Black Americans have less access to quality preschool. Speaking of kids, if one of them gets hurt or sick, they'll face longer ER wait times and receive less pain meds than white kids. So let's say another 5 Black people don't make it to court because their daycare provider called in sick or they spent the whole night in the ER, whereas 3 white people face the same problems. We're down to 37 Black people and 43 white.

Those who can't appear at the hearing may try to contact the court about rescheduling. Those with stereotypically Black-sounding names, though, are less likely to get a response. Research finds that government officials, including sheriffs, librarians, and school district reps, respond less to emails from DeShawn and Tyrone than from Greg and Jake.

How about physically getting to the courthouse? In most of the US, driving is the default option—for those with a car. Yet while just 6 percent of white households lack access to a car, 18 percent of Black households are carless. This disparity is not just because Black Americans have, on average, less money than white Americans. Even white and Black people with similar finances have dissimilar access to vehicles. For example, used car salespeople offer higher initial prices to Black consumers and are less willing to negotiate.

Among our remaining 80 people who do have a car, some are less likely to get to the courthouse without being stopped along the way. Black drivers are stopped 20 percent more often. We're down to 34 Black people, 44 white.

If you're skeptical, you might be wondering something like, "well what if Black people speed more?" It's possible. But using data from the rideshare app Lyft, researchers found no differences in driving

speeds by race. Nevertheless, Lyft drivers of color were 24–33 percent more likely to get pulled over than white drivers, and they paid 23–34 percent more in fines.

Other commuters rely on public transportation. But neighborhoods with more Black residents tend to have fewer public transit options. These neighborhoods are also farther from business districts, city centers, and courthouses. Research finds that a [one-hour increase](#) in transit time doubles people's rate of eviction. In a segregated world, this disparity, like the others, falls along racial lines. (Things could be structured differently. During the COVID-19 pandemic, eviction proceedings were held virtually on Zoom. Showing up to court suddenly got much easier. One Philadelphia study found that this structural change eliminated the impact of distance from the courthouse on eviction rates.)

Of the public transport takers, a few of our remaining 78 people realize at the bus stop that they forgot their fare cards. It's a mistake nearly everyone's made, yet they won't all face the same consequences for that same mistake. One experiment found that bus drivers, wittingly or not, were [two times more likely](#) to allow white people to ride for free than Black people. Let's say 4 Black people fail to make it because the bus driver won't let them on, or the bus fails to arrive at all, whereas only 2 white people miss the hearing for the same reason. Now we're down to 30 and 42.

And for those who finally do make it to the hearing? They'll meet judges who dole out harsher judgments to Black people than white.

The above describes *structural racism*, which is [one species of structural injustice](#). Disadvantage accumulates when one group of people faces more obstacles than another. The question is not whether Black people can overcome all these obstacles if they try hard enough. The injustice here is precisely that they have more obstacles in their way. They face a different set of choices, and different consequence for the choices they make. That's unfair.

Choices are shaped by *social structures*, which include laws, norms, history, and culture. Social structures also include the way neighborhoods, police jurisdictions, congressional maps, and economies are laid out. Pick any one part of life—like going to school—and there are umpteen social structures organizing it, from what time the bell rings in the morning (affecting how much sleep kids get) to the number of kids in the classroom (shaping how much attention they get) [to the grades they receive](#) (influencing what kinds of opportunities they'll have in the future).

There's plenty of scholarly debate about the best way to understand social structures. We'll define them as the more or less stable features of our shared, external social worlds. These features contrast with what's inside people, like their [beliefs, goals, and personality traits](#). Some kids are eager beavers ready to start school at 8:10 a.m., and others are night owls who have to be dragged out of bed at noon. Differences in such internal traits can lead kids to react to a shared social structure—in this case, the time school starts—differently.

To get a more complete view, we need to take a closer look at how racial inequity is woven into our neighborhoods, cities, and cultures—why conversations about racism quickly become conversations about real estate.

Residential Racial Segregation and the Maneuvering of People into Poverty

If you happen to own an old home in Seattle, the language of racial segregation may still linger in your house's deed. Two hundred and eighty parcels of the Roxbury Heights subdivision, for example, formed in 1942, were subject to the rule that "No person of any race other than the white race shall use or occupy any building or any lot, except this covenant shall not prevent occupancy by domestic servants of a different race domiciled with an owner or tenant." Deeds like this aren't rare. The University of Washington keeps a list of [racially restrictive covenants](#). By now they're legally voided, but they're still available for anyone to see. The list is depressingly long, and it's just for Seattle.

Policies like these represent one move in the long history of American racial oppression. Many of them were responses to the Great Migration, the movement of about six million Black Americans out of the

South over the twentieth century. Across the country, white Americans did just about everything possible to preserve segregation, not just against Black Americans moving out of the South but also against immigrants and other non-white groups. And the segregationists have been winning. [Eighty percent of American cities](#) are more segregated today than they were in 1990, and the trend is continuing in that direction.

Some say residential [racial segregation is the “linchpin”](#) or “structural ground” of contemporary racial inequality. They point to segregation’s power to lock other racial injustices in place. Malcolm X explained it with characteristic verve in 1963:

Our people are scientifically maneuvered by the white man into a life of poverty. Because we are forced to live in the poorest sections of the city, we attend inferior schools. We have inferior teachers and we get an inferior education. The white power structure downtown makes certain that by the time our people do graduate, we won’t be equipped or qualified for anything but the dirtiest, heaviest, poorest-paying jobs. Jobs that no one else wants. We are trapped in a vicious cycle of economic, intellectual, social, and political death. Inferior jobs, inferior housing, inferior education which in turn again leads to inferior jobs. We spend a lifetime in this vicious circle.

Historian Thomas Sugrue put it succinctly: “geography is destiny.” [“Zoning” is the term](#) used in the US for the methods and laws that municipalities and other local governments use to divide land into different zones (e.g., residential, commercial, industrial) and regulate how those different zones can be developed. While seemingly banal, it remains among the most significant causes of race- and class-based injustice. In 1922, then Secretary of State Herbert Hoover pushed for the Standard State Zoning Enabling Act, which delegated decision-making about land use to local communities. Now that cities couldn’t pass laws explicitly excluding Black people, they turned to zoning rules. In one example among many, Ford moved a factory—including all 1,400 employees, of which about 250 were Black—from Richmond, Virginia to the outskirts of Milpitas, California. [Milpitas quickly moved](#) to incorporate the new factory within its city limits and then to ban apartment buildings and ensure that only “qualified buyers” (i.e., white people) could secure a mortgage for a home.

This maneuvering spilled over into the nefarious practice known as redlining, which began in the 1930s and wasn’t outlawed until 1968. The term comes from the practice of financial institutions using color-coded real estate maps to rank neighborhoods by the likelihood that homebuyers there could pay off their mortgages. Neighborhoods deemed “too risky” for housing loans were colored red. Mortgage lenders stayed away, making it extremely difficult for residents of those neighborhoods to purchase their own homes or sell them to new buyers. [Redlining systematically shut people out](#) of the American Dream.

How was a neighborhood’s “risk” level determined? Rather than say the quiet part out loud—that loans shouldn’t be given to Black families—agencies like the federal government’s [Home Owners’ Loan Corporation](#) based their ratings on proxies for race.

Mortgages, it is said, [are like time machines](#): They allow you to have the future you want but today. But thanks to redlining, not everyone got the time machines. The invention of the modern mortgage was integral to one of the greatest periods of intergenerational wealth building in US history, but the boom was largely restricted to white people. Over the course of more than three decades, from the mid-1930s to the late 1960s, [non-white applicants received](#) just 2 percent of federally approved loans. In some places, the only option available to aspiring Black homeowners was to accept unorthodox loans from predatory “contract sellers.” These involved large down payments and high interest rates. Buyers would only be granted ownership of the home after the contract was paid in full and so garnered no equity while making monthly payments. One estimate found that in the 1950s and 1960s, Black families in Chicago alone lost [\\$3 to \\$4 billion](#) to contract sellers.

The Cycle Is the Story: The Cascading Effects of Injustice

None of these racist housing maneuvers happened in isolation. The GI Bill that sent a generation of World War II veterans to college was de facto unavailable to Black soldiers. Using the same tactics that worked to restrict the benefits of the New Deal to white people, [Southern members of Congress insisted](#) the GI Bill be administered at the state level, and Jim Crow laws made it nearly impossible for Black veterans to take advantage of it in many states.

There were countervailing victories, of course. The 1968 Fair Housing Act outlawed new forms of explicit housing discrimination. Probably as a result, [residential segregation declined](#) during the 1970s. But the law did little to counteract manipulations of zoning laws and mortgage lending practices.

Other putative victories ended up yielding mixed results too. When *Brown v. Board of Education of Topeka* outlawed racial segregation in public schools in 1954, redlining and other forms of residential segregation became popular tools for keeping white schools white. They appear to have worked. In 2021, about 40 percent of American public school students attended racially segregated schools, and currently, [four out of five students](#) at low-income schools are Black or Hispanic.

The story of residential racial segregation not only highlights the structural features of racism in the United States. It also illustrates the cascading effects of these arrangements. When public schools are financed through local property taxes—as they overwhelmingly have been in the US—[poorer areas will have poorer schools](#). If Black Americans live in segregated poorer neighborhoods, then Black kids will get a worse education. What's more, children living in predominantly Black neighborhoods are exposed to more environmental toxins like lead, whose harmful influence on cognition can be detected in math and reading scores.

The cascading effects of segregation don't stop there. Residents of impoverished neighborhoods also have less access to banks (as opposed to payday lenders), public transportation, decent grocery stores, and jobs offering better pay. Researchers call this [“spatial mismatch”](#): poorer people don't live near the services and opportunities that would benefit them.

Residents in segregated neighborhoods also have longer and more difficult commutes, increasing their transportation costs and the “time tax” they pay to get to work. Segregation also “taxes” people by limiting their social networks. “It's not what you know but who you know” is one of life's great truths, and it drives home how important it is to *have the opportunities* to know the right people. Missing such opportunities because of where you live is yet another cascading effect of segregation.

This last example highlights a particularly important aspect of structural racism. The cycle is the story. Segregation leads to unequal schools, which leads to unequal opportunities, which leads to unequal wealth, which leads to more segregation.

Once set in motion, the whole cyclical process can keep chugging along, without anyone at the wheel. Imagine you're hiring for a company you work for. Wouldn't you be grateful for a tip from someone you trust about a well-qualified candidate? Giving a special look to someone with a personal reference surely isn't racist, or even wrong. We help friends out all the time. Nevertheless, in a racially segregated society where white people are overwhelmingly likely to have mostly white friends, the practice of favoring friends perpetuates injustice. As the philosopher Elizabeth Anderson puts it, [“segregation along lines of social inequality is the key feature that turns otherwise innocent \[choices\] into vectors of . . . injustice.”](#)

There are plenty of intentionally and unintentionally biased [people contributing to segregation](#). But focusing on individually biased people leaves the structural drivers of unfairness out of the story. Even if someone could snap their fingers and eliminate every racist idea in every human's head, racial injustice would persist. People of color would still wake up the next morning, and the morning after that, in neighborhoods with worse schools, fewer jobs, more pollution, and less justice. Because of how social structures organize our world, people of color face unfair obstacles even when other people aren't treating them in prejudiced ways.

[Many companies today](#) say they're trying to root out the biases in their hiring practices and recruit people from different walks of life. They're not always genuine but sometimes they are. Even then, residential segregation and spatial mismatch create formidable challenges. The people these companies

want to hire don't hear about the job openings, and employers don't know how to find them. And even if employers and employees find each other, segregation might make a Black recruit's commute to work double the distance of their white colleague's. Hence the saying about (and by) Black strivers in the United States: you have to be [twice as good to get half as much](#).

If simply making people less prejudiced won't uproot structural racism, what will? The overturning of exclusionary zoning laws would be a good start. Maybe we need a massive social movement too. Either way, how do we do these things? In the last chapter, we explored how the dark arts of corporate PR shifted blame for problems like climate change off companies and governments and onto individuals. These PR campaigns created "litterbugs" and "personal carbon footprints" to distract people from more impactful collective action. It turns out that similar tactics have stymied the collective fight against structural racism.

How Not to Resist Structural Racism

Seventeen-year-old Darnella Frazier could not have known what she was about to set in motion when she pulled out her cellphone on May 25, 2020, outside a convenience store where George Floyd had just been arrested for attempting to use a counterfeit \$20 bill to buy cigarettes. During the arrest, officer Derek Chauvin pinned Floyd to the ground, pressing his knee to Floyd's neck. Floyd pleaded and called out for his mother for over eight minutes. While other officers either knelt on Floyd's back or stood by and did nothing, and a growing crowd of onlookers begged for them to stop, Frazier started recording. Floyd was eventually taken to a hospital but died due to injuries from the arrest.

Frazier's video helped spark what became known as the Black Lives Matter (BLM) protests, which peaked on June 6, 2020, with over half a million people marching in at least 550 cities. Over the course of about a month, [between 15 and 26 million people](#) participated in the demonstrations—the largest in US history.

The protests demanded justice for Floyd, and much more. They insisted police stop using excessive force on Black Americans. They called for profound transformations of the entire criminal justice system. They demanded the end of cash bail. They demanded alternative responses to people experiencing mental health crises. They demanded community oversight of police departments. BLM has come to stand for a whole set of ideas, ways the system needs to change to treat Black and brown people with respect and dignity.

One effect of the protests was immediately noticeable: a hiring spree. In the three months following Floyd's murder, the largest publicly traded companies in the United States [tripled their hiring](#) of chief diversity officers. Job openings focused on diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) surged by 50 percent in June 2020. This response increased the growth of what had already become big business. According to some estimates, US companies spend around \$8 billion a year on diversity initiatives, most prominently on paying consultants for diversity and antibias training. By 2021, the DEI industry was projected to continue to grow dramatically, surpassing \$15 billion a year by 2026. (These projections may have been too bullish, however; the hiring spree has cooled since 2021, and has even been reversed at some corporations and universities.)

This was not, to put it gently, on BLM's list of demands. It's hard to imagine protestors passionately chanting "No justice, no peace! Hire more diversity chiefs!" The diversity hiring boom was exactly the kind of Band-Aid response to racial injustice the BLM movement was criticizing. Diversity workshops, racial sensitivity trainings, and courageous conversations have been common practice, even in police departments, for decades.

Suspicion of the true motives behind the boom in DEI hiring came nearly as immediately as the boom itself. In an article titled "Workplace 'Anti-Racism' Trainings Aren't Working," for the socialist magazine *Jacobin*, [J. C. Pan wrote](#), "workplace antiracism training isn't a practice that anyone invested in the well-being of workers of any race should defend. The problem with such trainings isn't that they push

‘un-American propaganda’ or ‘neo-Marxist’ ideas in the workplace as the Right has fretted, but rather, that they increasingly allow employers to consolidate their power over employees under a veneer of social justice.”

All this hiring *is* good for at least one thing: preventing lawsuits. An unironic article on the Leaders’ Choice Insurance website, for example, is titled “Conduct Diversity Training to [Head Off Potential Lawsuits](#).” When a business or a school demonstrates that it required everyone to complete a DEI event, it can say it took proactive action to prevent discrimination. The implication—left unspoken—is that nothing further in the institution’s culture or policies needs fixing. After the organization “checks the box” saying that everyone completed the training, they can blame future discriminatory actions on misbehaving individual employees. [Pan gets at the economic sense of this](#): “a weeklong anti-racism workshop that costs an employer tens of thousands of dollars is still cheaper than a discrimination lawsuit (or raising workers’ wages).” As *Jacobin*’s founding editor Bhaskar Sunkara put it, “Inclusivity seminars . . . protect power; they don’t challenge it. We’re being hustled.”

Although there’s more to (some) diversity trainings than these critics allege (see chapter 5), nobody who’s seeking progressive change should want to be a mark for forces like these. Structural racism is an “everything problem” like climate change. In both cases, the forces defending the status quo have roots hundreds of years deep and tendrils in nearly every part of daily life. They won’t be undone by shopping better or one-hour diversity trainings alone. We need to set our sights on structural change: what it is and how to create it.

Change Against the Machine: Structural Change in the Public Mind

Big Structural Change

We've seen that too much focus on what individuals can do in their own little corners of the world diverts attention from the real action: the pursuit of transformative, structural change. But what is structural change, and how does it happen?

Structural changes promise to be big. They're significant and far-reaching, in contrast to the itty-bitty changes individuals can make on their own. Senator Elizabeth Warren built her 2020 presidential campaign around the demand for "[Big Structural Change](#)." Her proudest example of "a structural fix" was the creation of her brainchild, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, a "new government agency whose sole mission was to look out for consumers." The agency set out to fight banks and other companies on behalf of bilked citizens.

Also in the [2020 Democratic primary](#), Pete Buttigieg backed "structural democratic reforms," including the dissolution of the Electoral College and statehood for Washington, DC. Cory Booker campaigned on ending "structural inequality and institutional racism," through, for example, a "baby bond" bill that would give every child born in the US \$1,000, with more funds given each year, especially to poorer children. Bernie Sanders promised "to treat structural racism with the exigency it deserves" by, for example, ending the "war on drugs"; abolishing cash bail, capital punishment, and private prisons; guaranteeing every American a job; automatically registering every eighteen-year-old to vote; and granting free, high-quality healthcare to all.

Others have focused beyond law and policy, on versions of structural change that don't go through government. In January 1969, the Black Panther Party worked with a local Oakland priest to start offering [free breakfast to children](#) at a church. Funded through donations and staffed with volunteers, the program rapidly expanded nationwide, serving thousands of children in twenty cities by the end of the year. Eventually, this did provoke government action. The federal government passed its own permanent breakfast program in 1975, which to this day feeds nearly 15 million children every morning. (The federal government stepped in only after systematically dismantling the Black Panther Party, murdering several of its leaders, and discrediting their free breakfast program, which Federal Bureau of Investigation [FBI] Director J. Edgar Hoover called "a front for [indoctrinating children with Panther propaganda](#).")

Whenever people make it easier or harder to eat breakfast, vote, cross national borders, access unemployment insurance, buy a gun, or get a gas-guzzler or an electric car, they're changing the structures that shape everyday life. These background structures act like fuel or friction for our personal choices. They make some options easy and obvious and others hidden and arduous.

Many people think that seriously tackling "everything problems" like climate change and racism will require a revolutionary transformation to a new global order, on par with the transitions from hunter-gatherer societies to farming economies and from [feudal kingdoms to capitalist democracies](#).

One of the biggest transformations was what the Nobel laureate economist Angus Deaton calls [humanity's "Great Escape"](#). For almost all the roughly 300,000 years that modern human beings have existed, the average lifespan was about thirty-five years. Child mortality held the average down; roughly one-third of children died before puberty. Aside from small fluctuations around big harvests or disease outbreaks, these numbers remained the same until about the middle of the eighteenth century. Change came slowly at first and mostly in Europe. But the escape from truncated life started to take off with astounding speed and reach at the end of the nineteenth century, eventually achieving a global average of

seventy-three years by 2019. To put that in perspective, in the last 0.05 percent of our species’ existence, the typical [human life has doubled](#) in length.

This is astonishing, but it’s only part of the truly transformative changes human beings have experienced over the past 200 years. Suppose the world consisted of 100 people:

In 1820	In 2020
—88 people were illiterate, while 12 could read.	—14 people were illiterate, while 86 could read.
—83 people received no formal education, while 17 received at least a basic education.	—14 people received no formal education, while 86 received at least a basic education.
—99 people didn’t live in a democracy and only 1 did.	—44 people didn’t live in a democracy, while 56 did.
—84 people were living in extreme poverty and 16 were not.	—9 people were living in extreme poverty and 91 were not (though 76 were still poor).
—Nobody was vaccinated against anything.	—14 people weren’t vaccinated against anything and 86 were.

Dramatic changes like these have many causes. They include revolutions overthrowing governments, important laws being passed or repealed, progress in science and technology, and cultures adopting norms that spread from the margins to the mainstream. Some such changes are unintended, like the US military experimenting with networked computers, which became the internet, which became [“Distracted Boyfriend” memes](#) and TikTok. Others have been driven by disasters, like the 1666 Great Fire of London that gave rise to modern city planning. Others still have been driven by invention: vaccines and antibiotics, planes and trains, nuclear fission, and maybe next artificial intelligence.

It’s rarely the case that things simply get better overall. For all the tremendous advances of the last 200 years, the biggest societal challenges we face today—inequality, biodiversity loss, democratic backsliding—are in some ways products of the very things that made those changes possible, like cheap fossil fuels and racial exploitation.

Structural change also happens piecemeal and unevenly. Many people live in abject poverty even as the world as a whole grows richer. Some children—especially in marginalized communities of color—continue to die young despite rising averages in lifespan. A 2023 California study found that [for every 100,000 births](#), 173 babies born to wealthy white women die before they turn one, whereas 653 born to poor Black women do.

There’s plenty of room to disagree about which social structures we ought to try to change and how we ought to do it. Even among advocates for change who agree about structural goals—decarbonization, racial equity, ending poverty—there’s ongoing, complex, and reasonable debate about what to do. For example, staving off the climate crisis requires scaling up the extraction of minerals for “clean” technology, like batteries to power electric cars. Many of these mining efforts have disproportionately harmed indigenous and marginalized communities. But the solution to climate change can’t be a strategy that poisons the least well-off and tramples their ways of life. The steps to decarbonization have to be [fair, safe, and democratic](#).

Maybe global warming can’t be reversed without a world-historical transformation, like the death of capitalism. Or maybe it can. It’s possible that multifaceted incremental progress through a hodgepodge of

less radical reforms, from tax rebates for induction stoves to new ways to sequester carbon pollution in concrete, can get the job done. We don't know. For the rest of the book, though, we'll take "structural change" to include all the above.

Either/Or Thinking

Otherwise commendable demands for structural change too often slip into either/or thinking. People demand structural change *instead of* individual change. In the coming chapters, we'll make the case that changing people and changing systems are interconnected and mutually reinforcing. They're complements rather than competitors. Either/or thinking can be deceptively appealing, though, so a key step in escaping it is getting a clearer picture of what it is and how it works.

Start with what social psychologists Keith Payne and Jason Hannay predict are among the best ways to tackle racial injustice: "policies that directly increase racial equality and participation, such as voting rights legislation and affirmative action policies, are likely to have more impact than changing attitudes." In another essay, [Payne and Heidi Vuletich insist](#) that "solutions need to focus on structuring the social context, rather than changing the beliefs or values of individuals." Claims like these don't just portray changing individual attitudes as *insufficient* for combating racial inequality and bias. They're not advocating that we change both attitudes and structures. They're saying we can't have it both ways.

Historian Ibram X. Kendi draws out this line of thinking in vivid, autobiographical detail. He describes his own escape from the more individualist view he held at an earlier time in his life: "[I became a college professor](#) to educate away racist ideas, seeing ignorance as the source of racist ideas, seeing racist ideas as the source of racist policies, seeing mental change as the principal solution, seeing myself, an educator, as the primary solver."

Over time, however, Kendi came to see things exactly the other way around, believing that racist "policies"—such as slavery, segregation, and mass incarceration—are the source of racist ideas:

I was taught the popular folktale of racism: that ignorant and hateful people had produced racist ideas, and that these racist people had instituted racist policies. But when I learned the motives behind the production of many of America's most influentially racist ideas, it became quite obvious that this folktale, though sensible, was not based on a firm footing of historical evidence. Ignorance/hate racist ideas discrimination: this causal relationship is largely ahistorical. It has actually been the inverse relationship—racial discrimination [that is, large-scale racially discriminatory policies and structures like segregation] led to racist ideas which led to ignorance and hate. Racial discrimination racist ideas ignorance/hate: this is the causal relationship driving America's history of race relations.

On this view, racist ideas are what philosophers call "epiphenomenal"—they're [a by-product, not a cause](#). If racist ideas are mere by-products of racist policies, then we ought to focus on changing the policies rather than the ideas. To borrow a concept from the economist Douglass North, we should work to change the "[rules of the road](#)" that structure individual choice. Systems and structures are the problem, Kendi and Payne and North would say, so changing them—rather than individual hearts and minds—is the solution.

There's something right about this, especially the insistence that we keep our sights set on structural change. But there's also something troublingly incomplete about it. What could it possibly mean to change racist policies "directly?" [Without persuading anyone](#) to do anything differently?

This either/or thinking isn't specific to fighting racism. There was a massive decline in carbon pollution in 2020 due to COVID-19 lockdowns, when so many people stopped driving and traveling. Nevertheless, [carbon pollution rebounded](#) after the lockdowns ended. Robinson Meyer concluded that "this extraordinary and painful trial should provide the final proof, I think, that climate change simply cannot be solved by changing our personal behavior. We have to change systems." You'll remember that distracting people from supporting regulations was exactly the goal of corporate PR campaigns like Keep America Beautiful.

Meyer is rightly fighting back against that long history, trying to redirect attention toward important but obscured sources of the problem. But his use of either/or thinking again raises the question of how systems will change if nobody has to change their personal behavior.

Other times, either/or thinking is offered as a corrective against pernicious kinds of victim blaming, which happen when too much responsibility is foisted on individuals. Most of us have no choice but to live in a world powered by fossil fuels, so thinking that the climate crisis requires individuals to take personal responsibility for their carbon footprints seems akin to blaming those who aren't at fault. But even though it's wrong to blame victims, somebody should do something!

The fogginess surrounding the idea of what one person can do to change systems drives other instances of either/or thinking, too. [Political scientist Matto Mildener](#) writes, "Yes, it's great to drive an electric vehicle (if you can afford it) and purchase solar panels (if powerful utilities in your state haven't conspired to make renewable energy more expensive). But the point is that *interest groups have structured the choices available to us today. Individuals don't have the agency* to steer our economic ship from the passenger deck." Mildener goes on to talk about the importance of joining a social movement to fight climate change, and we'll say more about that later. For now, notice the framework here: bad systems have made it so that individuals don't have the agency to create change. It's moments like these when, we fear, necessary corrections become troubling overcorrections. The well-taken concern that people have been investing their efforts to fight climate change and racism in misguided and individualist ways drifts into despair. If no one has agency, well then, [I guess we're done here](#).

Individual Change or Structural Change: Which Comes First?

Besides the motivational morass that comes from being told "personal behavior doesn't matter," the obvious problem with either/or thinking is that *someone* is going to have to make change. [Civil rights activist Bayard Rustin](#) once posed the question: "What is more important to bring about change as a society, changed individuals or a changed social structure? The answer to that is very simple because if you don't start out with individuals who are determined to change something, you will never get a political consensus." Rustin takes for granted that both individual change and structural change are necessary. He avoids the pitfalls of simplistic little-things-add-up individualist thinking. As one of the main organizers of the 1963 March on Washington, he knows as well as anyone that antiracist responsibilities can't be met simply by overcoming private prejudices.

Nevertheless, Rustin is, quite explicitly, still posing an either/or choice, about which kind of change to pursue first. His view seems to go like this. Step 1: change the hearts and minds. Step 2: build a political consensus. Step 3: use that consensus to change the structures. This represents [a subtler form of either/or thinking](#), and one with intuitive appeal.

Rustin's approach raises problems. You'll remember that DEI workshops have largely failed to move the hearts-and-minds needle in meaningful ways. Part of the problem is that these workshops are embedded in and serve the lawsuit-dodging aims of organizations. Maybe, then, the work of changing hearts and minds should take place [outside corporate contexts, within alternative structures](#). The new question becomes, What kinds of social structures must be in place to change individuals so that those individuals go on to build a consensus and change social structures?

Another common and plausible position is that both individual and structural change are important but [structural change is more important](#). In "What 'Structural Racism' Really Means," Jamelle Bouie brings us back to a 1948 book called *Class, Caste, and Race: A Study in Social Dynamics*, by the Trinidadian sociologist Oliver Cromwell Cox. Cox ties racism to economic exploitation, positioning his framework as an alternative to the more familiar way of thinking of racism in terms of false beliefs about group differences or tribal animus (i.e., bad hearts and misled minds). Building on Cox, Bouie writes, "We must remember that the problem of racism—of the denial of personhood and of the differential exposure to exploitation and death—will not be resolved by saying the right words or thinking the right thoughts.

That's because racism does not survive, in the main, because of personal belief and prejudice. It survives because it is inscribed and reinscribed by the relationships and dynamics that structure our society, from segregation and exclusion to inequality and the degradation of labor."

Bouie is careful to say that racism doesn't survive "in the main" because of individual prejudice. He's not fully either/or. He acknowledges that individual prejudice contributes to the problems of racism rather than dismissing it as a mere by-product. On the other hand, Bouie also holds that individual prejudice can only be fully understood in terms of how it's inscribed into "the dynamics that structure our society." Those dynamics are the most important thing—[they take priority](#).

This is puzzling. Consider what Bouie says when describing what to do to change structures of racial exploitation. He continues:

The solution, as the Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. wrote in the year of his assassination, must involve a "revolution of values" that will "look uneasily on the glaring contrast of poverty and wealth" and see that "an edifice which produces beggars needs restructuring. If democracy is to have breadth of meaning," King declared, "it is necessary to adjust this inequity. It is not only moral, but it is also intelligent. We are wasting and degrading human life by clinging to archaic thinking."

Truly addressing structural racism would require a revolution in values and abandoning archaic thinking. Bouie endorses this here but also says earlier in the essay that racism will not be solved by getting people to think the right thoughts.

What he most likely means is that racism will never be solved if *all* we do is think different thoughts. It's difficult to disagree. But which values and thoughts? And more importantly, which values and thoughts lead to guilt-absolving insignificant choices and which [lead instead to system-changing action](#)?

Toward a Both/And Picture of Social Change

We're equal opportunity skeptics when it comes to "most important" and first movers of any kind. What happens in hearts and minds surely matters, but what causes those changes in people's hearts and minds is often . . . changes to systems and structures. What causes changes to those systems and structures is often . . . people with conviction in their hearts and new ideas in their minds.

Instead of dichotomies and linear sequences and first movers, we favor an alternative picture, one featuring constant feedback between people and systems. As we'll explore in the coming chapters, norms and expectations, culture and hierarchies, and institutions and laws are the very things that cause us to make the individual choices we do.

When people get motivated to fight climate change because a hurricane or heat wave affects them personally, they're acting as structurally situated individuals. They're not heroic loners springing into being *ex nihilo*. Their choices and aims are shaped by the effects of the literal, physical structure of the city they've been living in, perhaps one with crumbling climate-vulnerable roads and buildings. Similarly, when indigenous people in Ecuador rise up to resist the exploitative and toxic practices of resource extraction in their communities, they're *reacting* to and resisting the unjust structures that oppress them. Whenever someone says "change comes first from within," we say "but what change causes that?" Their supposed first mover, the individual, has to be moved.

Individuals aren't prior to structures because structures motivate or demotivate, incentivize or prohibit, provide fuel or friction to individual action. Structures aren't prior to individuals either. Whether those structures last or crumble depends inevitably on what people think and feel about them. Frederick Douglass knew this well: "[Power concedes nothing without a demand](#). It never did and it never will. Find

out just what any people will submit to, and you have found out the exact amount of injustice and wrong which will be imposed upon them; and these will continue till they are resisted with either words or blows, or with both. The limits of tyrants are prescribed by the endurance of those whom they oppress.”

Resistance to injustice can't be understood in either/or terms. It exists both inside people (in their willingness to resist) and outside them (in the institutions they're rejecting). So how can we avoid slipping into either/or thinking, and what do we put in its place? Moving forward requires looking back. So we begin with two lessons from history.